Mahadev, and brands allegedly associated with it, such as Gold365, SkyExchange, Tiger Exchange and Laser247, generated up to Rs 94,400 crore in revenue from Indian customers over a decade, according to the ED's provisional estimate submitted in court. These platforms offered bets on virtually anything—from cricket match outcomes and runs in a single over to football, tennis and kabaddi, as well as card games such as poker and teen patti, virtual slot machines, roulette and other casino-style games. Behind the slick digital interfaces, investigators allege, lay a network of local operators, offshore 'checkers', fraudulent bank accounts and shell companies (see *Inside Mahadev*).

HOW THE SCAM FLOURISHED

To understand the scale of the scam, one must understand why these platforms became popular. Online betting moved gambling from the networks of local bookmakers and betting dens to smartphones. Enabled by widespread internet access and digital payments, customers could open accounts, place bets and collect winnings with a few taps.

Two distinct types of businesses operated within this universe. The first consisted of offshore bookmakers, such as Mahadev, Parimatch and 1xBet, accepting wagers on sporting events and gambling games. The second was India's burgeoning domestic real-money gaming industry, spanning fantasy sports, rummy, poker and other games in which you could pay an entry fee or stake money for a chance to win cash prizes. The industry argued, with judicial backing dating to a 1968 Supreme Court ruling on rummy, that their products were predominantly games of skill and thus legally distinct from gambling.

The distinction was crucial. For decades, Indian gambling laws and court rulings had recognised the difference between games governed by chance and those requiring skill. It enabled several domestic companies to operate in a legal environment that varied from state to state. The offshore bookmakers, meanwhile, exploited the same fragmented regulatory landscape, operating from jurisdictions largely beyond the reach of Indian law enforcement agencies. By early 2025, the scale of foreign betting activity set off alarm bells. A Digital India Foundation study noted some 1.6 billion visits from India to selected websites of just four offshore operators—Parimatch, Stake, 1xBet and Battery Bet—in a three-month period, between October and December 2024.

Concern was mounting on several fronts. There was the social cost: young people and financially vulnerable customers being enticed by the possibility of quick winnings, sometimes losing significant savings or accumulating debts through repeated gambling. There was the fiscal cost:

INSIDE MAHADEV

1 THE FRANCHISE

- Mahadev promoters allegedly franchised betting brands such as Tiger Exchange, Gold365 and Laser247 to associates, retaining 70-75% of the business
- Around 4,000 staff, known as checkers, monitored betting exposure from Dubai villas, often working 12-hour shifts



2 THE OPERATOR



- Local operators paid around ₹15 lakh as earnest money to obtain a coded panel under a specific betting brand
- The network allegedly ran up to 3,200 live panels
- A successful panel, according to investigators, generated ₹30-40 lakh a month; operators earned ₹3.5-60 crore each

IN THE CROSSHAIRS

*THE ALLEGED MAHADEV MASTERMINDS**



SAURABH CHANDRAKAR, *31*

- **Ran a juice shop in Bhilai, Chhattisgarh, before moving to Dubai in 2019, where he allegedly helped build Mahadev into a sprawling offshore betting syndicate**
- **His lavish wedding in Ras Al-Khaimah in Feb. 2023 brought the network into the spotlight; briefly detained in Dubai in Oct. 2024**
- **Allegedly arrested in Oman in June 2026 for using forged passport; Indian authorities have since renewed efforts to extradite him**



RAVI UPPAL *mid-40s*

- **A Bhilai native allegedly already entrenched in betting, he is suspected to have introduced Chandrakar to the trade**
- **Detained briefly in Dubai in Dec. 2023 following an Interpol Red Notice; current whereabouts remain unknown**
- **He challenged the Red Notice, calling the cases politically motivated**

**Both have vehemently denied any association with the alleged racket*